





ASSISTANT SCULPTOR TO Prof. MANSOUR TABIBZADEH — National Stone Symposium, Tabriz, 2015
Monumental Portrait of the Poet Jalāl al-Din RŪMĪ (1207-1273) / Serpentine Stone / 1.2 × 1.2 × 2.5m

MEMORY | GAZE | DEPARTURE | GRIEF

STUDIO-NOTES: SELF AS POSITION OF IN-BETWEEN

PAIN without Redemption — FORM without Surrender

5:7 JUXTAPOSITION OF BURNING: MATERIAL AS WITNESS BETWIXT OXYGEN AND TRUTH, STONE GUIDES BREATH TO THINK

"IT'S FIRE NOT JUST HOT AIR THE REED-FLUTE'S CRY" —RUMI, trans. by
Jawid Mojaddedi

There, beside Tabibzadeh, stone was not merely hammered or cut; it was listened to, approached, and slowly invited to breathe by the gaze it slowly pierced through the dust it spread. Back then, that dust in midair was the only barrier between the oxygen I was breathing and the truth I felt equipped to investigate.

There, through stone, dust and breath, truth no longer appeared as an object awaiting pursuit. It shifted my perception toward a discipline of hope: a practice of Care that demands study and research prior to risk, cost and labour; denouncing Hope as mere mood, or the escapist promise of hedonism.

What fell away was the fantasy of freedom as pure artistic will. Creation began to open a horizon of fidelity, where form negotiates with material, memory, and the collective conditions that exceed the limits of desire for destination, possession, or moral certainty.

Haqiqat in Farsi — carrying divine right, inevitable truth, and the authentic essence of being — articulates truth beyond the poverty of translation: not as certainty, but as a living discipline throughout practice; a force drawn toward the honesty of its own nature, disarming lies by revealing history as testimony to its unmatched reality, whose proximity burns, yet is longed for.

3:7 A WORLD HELD IN A BREAK: TEA BEFORE FORM

HOPE ARRIVES THROUGH THE RITUALS OF THE ORDINARY

"BODY AND SOUL ARE JOINED TO FORM ONE WHOLE

BUT NO ONE IS ALLOWED TO SEE THE SOUL" —RUMI, trans. by
Jawid Mojaddedi

The Product of such embodied revival was an epistemic heritage: for its ethics, ontology, and methods form the autonomous and materially uncontested origin of my Praxis. Thus what endured from those years is not memory alone, but a living: a somatic repository of embodied knowledge and forms of care.

Migration proved this inheritance indispensable, even more so when displacement unfolded within what **García Márquez** called "*manglares de la selva europea*" — *mangroves of the European jungle* — a fitting image for Berlin's dense institutions, classed pathways, and historical sedimentations, whose waters grant access mainly to those *fluent in their currents*.

I must return at once to our small attic-like studio in Darakeh: to continue studying the anatomy of my sculpture, totally confused, while **Prof. Tabibzadeh** — wearing *his* khaki vest — counts the clean glasses for the tea break, then asks me to put the plate of food outside for the cats and bring some wood to cut for the fire pit.

از کجاها گِرد آمد در بدن

عرشی و فرشی و رومی و گشی

در تن خود بنگر این اجزای تن

آبی و خاکی و بادی و آتشی

4:7 OF A MONUMENT: THE REED, THE FLAME, THE DUST

"THE REED CONSOLES THOSE FORCED TO BE APART

ITS NOTES WILL LIFT THE VEIL UPON YOUR HEART" —RUMI, trans. by
Jawid Mojaddedi

Shortly before I left Iran for Switzerland to study Design, those sessions in Darakeh were concluded for me by an intense month at the *Tabriz National Stone Symposium* in 2015, as an assistant to Prof. Tabibzadeh. It was an adventure of hammering and cutting for up to fourteen hours a day, sculpting a giant piece of stone.

The portrait transformed into something much more than just a personal interpretation: as if manifesting a poetic confession, it carefully unfolded a monument of grief at the advent of the "common love." The subject of creation emerged as an objective gaze, metabolizing a physical depiction of a collective truth.

Rumi, the mystic poet of the thirteenth century, becomes the catalyst of his own reflection in poetry through the pain the moth must endure to reach the flames of its own desire, consumed by an embrace whose essence burns within a lament the reed sings for separation, so that the pain of such partings could animate the disguise of a union concealed within separation:

All of which passed through that "pearl of massive size."

جانِ مُرده یافت از وی جنبشی

مُرده پوشید از بقای او قبا

جانِ آتش یافت زو آتش گُشی

جانِ ناری یافت از وی انطفَا

1:7 THE TOOL REMEMBERS BEFORE HANDS DO

After concluding a modelling session at Mehdi's Drawing Club, I shared a short walk with a *friend*, who I knew from Ahmad Vakili's painting school in Tehran, speaking, as we often did, about art. Stopping by her car, I observed her sculpting tools on the back seat, resting beside a face mask and some unfinished wooden pieces. Noticing my gaze, she told me of Prof. Tabibzadeh and his Studio in Darakeh. A name I recalled well from Zahedan, where I had recently finished my Bachelor in Science and moved back to Tehran.

I still remember how terrified I felt the first time I approached him to borrow a polishing tool, when he asked me *not to use it on plaster*. Directing the woodworking Atelier, **Prof. Tabibzadeh** flew over a thousand Kilometers every two weeks to our *end of the world* at *Sistan and Baluchistan University complex*, offering a wide range of lectures from sculpture and *painting* to *aesthetics* and philosophy.

Initially celebrated as an artist for his vibrant wooden sculptures, Prof. Tabibzadeh soon became a prominent academic figure whose interdisciplinary approach to teaching cultivated critical discourses on poetics of space and collective memory— a legacy embodied also in his practice. I was fortunate to first encounter this spirit in Zahedan, intruding into *the art department*, which warmly welcomed me into its seminars, workshops, and corridors of art, extending compassion toward an outsider from *the engineering department* — a major chosen by my parents to *protect* me from what I wanted.



As I push the metal door back in, he is calling to Minoo to pause her work, waiting for everyone to sit. I ask for tobacco, reaching for the green Lucky Strike, and notice Payam, a big smile on his face, opening a fresh box of pastries while carefully listening to the story Ostād (Farsi: “master-teacher”) is sharing — as if offering rare seeds of hope in a ritual of memory.

Years later, when I first heard *James Baldwin* talk of those “very few people,” I was reminded of that room, and of a teacher whose “love and passion” were a blessing, holding our world together, while so much of it has been forced into rupture, since I was compelled to leave that studio, my family, friends and Iran behind.

7:7 GRIEF AS A SOMATIC METHOD OF RECEPTION

THE WOUND READS BEFORE THE MIND CAN NAME THE LOSS

"I USE THE DUST OF MY GRIEF AS SALVE FOR MY EYES,

THAT MY EYES, LIKE SEAS, MAY TEEM WITH PEARLS" —RUMI, trans. by
E. H. Whinfield

Maybe the ultimate realization was that a decision *in* the making is never made by force, nor by the tyranny of one's desire, but by acceptance, by embracing the *unexpected*; by preserving space for the emergence of what finds no initial reception, yet exposes the conditions that made its tale hidden, or impossible to tell.

While our hands were trained to dominate, our narrative was informed by submission to its subjects, guiding a Sufi-like labour that traced the truth by losing its trace and letting the Absence leave its pressure in the body. Perhaps this was where the craft began to guide our practice: Hands learning to follow whatever survives *inside material* and give form to what the *mind* arrives too late to name, even when survival speaks only *through fractures*; for fracture teaches form how to listen and the hands how to read.

Pain without redemption, and form without surrender; reminded by Hartman's "*critical fabulation*" — where the form learns to hold space for silence, *absence*, and grief, accepting the impossibility of fully recovering what violence has erased, by acknowledging the aftermath of Loss as an ongoing human condition:

FOR WHAT PROVES BEYOND REPAIR CAN YET BECOME LEGIBLE.

2:7 HOSPITALITY AND CARE: REFUSALS OF NEGLIGENCE

HOPE ARRIVES THROUGH THE RITUALS OF THE ORDINARY

"LOVE'S FIRE IS WHAT MAKES EVERY REED-FLUTE PINE

LOVE'S FERVOUR THUS LENDS POTENCY TO WINE" —RUMI, trans. by
Jawid Mojaddedi

Getting the contact from my friend, I visited his studio in Darakeh the following week, beginning a five-year journey that became the most transformative period of my training in arts and crafts. Soon, my primary focus shifted from metal and ceramics toward woodworking as the main area of my studies, shaping the framework of my artistic practice for years to come.

A formative chapter, tracing the poetics of form and labor, was spent within the confines of that Studio, tendering rare ventures of care and discipline that still guide me and my path, against which even a decade long academic journey in Art and Design seems peripheral at the margins of Swiss and European institutions.

Memories are a sanctuary of thought; a living repository, lodged in the body — coordinating muscles, gesture, ideas, or even ethics. When migration changed the conditions of survival, my memories have since formed a habitus for that embodied knowledge driving the cadence of my hands through each altered condition.

روزها با سوزها همراه شد

در غمِ ما روزها بیگاه شد

تو بمان ای آنکه چون تو پاک نیست

روزها گر رفت، گو رو، پاک نیست

6:7 THE WORK AS OFFERING: THE ETHICS OF MAKING

WHERE HANDS LEARN TO LISTEN; CREATION BEGINS

"THE STICK ALSO SAYS, I WAS ONCE A GREEN BRANCH" –RUMI, trans. by Arthur J. Arberry

Such was the *discipline* of hope we had practised, within humble walls of our studio *in* Darakeh. Grateful for the moments when the tea was poured and the carving *paused*. I still remember that fresh scent of walnut and cherry wood, settling a silken frost of dust across every surface, as if preserving our memories beneath, inviting us to listen to what remained of the tree: to the *lines* holding its weather, its wounds, where form negotiated with time and maybe the wind.

FIGURE STUDY – Torso in progress; Studio's Garden, Tehran, 2012



STUDIO-NOTES: Self as Position of in-between





The wood was never to be treated as passive material. It was yet to be approached as a witness, holding emotions inside its grain, unveiling hidden layers through the dialogue it allowed. So we were reminded that creation is never about the result alone, but about the *journey*, the process, the endeavour of exploring the depth of self within the remnants of earth's once prosperous children, which we often take for granted.

The log of wood *laid* before us as a Body capable of sheltering grief, bearing witness to what loss leaves absent — fostering a poetic response beyond the limitations of words, and surpassing any language that has ever claimed power over our lives. We were guided to listen more *than* we were taught how to carve, in a quest to rethink our creative process with patience and grace.